

The Gender CARD

BJP is now the only party to have 33 per cent quota for women

The male-dominated BJP is, ironically, the first political party to announce 33 per cent reservations for women at its organisational level. Piloted by the fiery Sushma Swaraj, a resolution to this effect was pushed through a unanimous voice vote. "There was a 4 per cent swing of women votes in Modi's favour, so women are favourably inclined towards BJP," said Swaraj.

While the decision will be implemented right from the local level, there is a caveat. It does not include the parliamentary board (the party's highest decision-making body) and the central office-bearers. It does, however, affect the 54-member national executive which will soon get 14 new faces. A male general secretary quipped that he had never seen so many men clapping at their own downfall. But for Swaraj, who has emerged as a gender mascot, this was clearly a moment of triumph.



WOMAN POWER:
Sushma Swaraj

SIPRA DAS



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The party needs Advani for the content and the gloss, while Vajpayee provides the background aura.

THE PRESENCE: Vajpayee remains the inspiration

committee and the fact that she was asked to present an election strategy paper at the national council underlines her importance in the party's scheme of things. Another Advani loyalist Naidu is tipped to head an unofficial core committee of the election management group. Is the party repeating an earlier mistake of peaking too early? "If you go down sharp, hilly roads, there is a sign that says: 'start early, drive steadily and reach safely'. We intend to reach safely," says Sudheendra Kulkarni, a former BJP secretary and an Advani confidant. Having just been given his licence to drive, Advani is hoping that this ride will finally take him to 7 Race Course Road. For the charioteer of Indian politics, that has always been the destination.

Advani's immediate challenge is the 10 assembly elections due this year. Four are in the North-east. Of the others, BJP is in power in three and Congress in two. "Gujarat has shown that the anti-incumbency factor can be overcome," said Advani. But directing the others to blindly follow the Modi model is not good enough. "It is not a one-size-fit-all. Each state has its own parameters. Caste is an issue in my state, it was not in Gujarat," points out Vasundhara Raje, Rajasthan chief minister. Some of Modi's colleagues seem

uncomfortable with his brand of politics. "We have done development work in Madhya Pradesh, more than Gujarat. Perhaps we have not marketed it as well," laughed Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan. It needs someone of Advani's stature to balance all the egos. He has already asked BJP not just to be a party with a difference but also to have politicians with a difference. This is the BJP that he wants to showcase in the next general elections, under his leadership.

Vajpayee will continue to play the role of party patriarch. The NDA resolution that nominated Advani's prime ministerial candidature has stressed this fact. The former prime minister still continues to be the NDA chairperson but the logistics of that role have passed on to Advani. The last NDA meeting was hosted at his residence instead of the customary Vajpayee house.

Does he, who has turned the position of number two into the longest existential crisis in politics, need to be a Vajpayee to remain number one? He has the allies behind him; he has managed to unite the various factions of the BJP's GenNext; and he also has a non-controversial, statesman-like agenda of good governance to sell. He is almost there at the V-level—only the poetry is lacking. ■